

On the flipside, IPL 2016 was won by Sunrisers Hyderabad on the back of exceptional seasons from openers David Warner (848 runs) and Shikhar Dhawan (501 runs), both of whom struggled at the preceding international event, averaging 9.50 and 10.75 respectively.

### Past performance does not indicate future returns

Dhawan and Warner are prime examples of the fact that performances in a T20 World Cup are not the strongest indicator of how a player will perform in the IPL, and the 2026 IPL season is unlikely to be any different.

Heading into the T20 World Cup 2026, many asked whether any team would be able to reach 300 in a T20I innings, with some even suggesting it could happen more than once. The genesis of that question has much to do with the IPL, where, enabled by batting-friendly wickets and the introduction of the Impact Player rule, run rates have skyrocketed and batting records have tumbled with ease.

Among the poster boys of that batting revolution are Abhishek Sharma and Phil Salt. Abhishek has been the spearhead of both SRH and India's attacking turn, while Salt has been similarly impressive for England and has won back-to-back IPL titles as an aggressive opening batter.

Both have made their name playing attacking cricket that naturally lends itself to high variance, taking high-risk options in search of high reward despite the greater threat of dismissal. Both, however, had middling World Cups, with the odd performance of note (including Abhishek's fifty in the final) punctuating campaigns replete with low scores.

While both are quality batters capable of destruction in any conditions, they have excelled on flatter, more batter-friendly wickets like those seen in the IPL over the last two years.

By contrast, the wickets at the T20 World Cup were — especially in the early stages — more even. Despite scoring rates being higher than any previous edition, batting was not as easy as it has been in the IPL and in bilaterals in the recent past, with pitches offering a touch more assistance to bowlers. Salt even played three innings in Sri Lanka, where runs were harder to come by than in India.

For high-risk, high-reward batters like Abhishek and Salt, this meant some reversion to the mean, with their wings clipped more often than in the immediately preceding period.

While both will undoubtedly have hoped for more fruitful returns at the World Cup, a return to familiar, more supportive conditions could easily trigger a return to the form that earned them reputations as two of the most dynamic batters on the

international circuit.

Conditions are not the only variable that will change heading into the IPL.

Suryakumar Yadav (**below**) began the T20 World Cup with an unbeaten 84 against the USA, but he was less successful thereafter, managing 158 runs from the next eight matches.

However, Suryakumar often found himself operating in a role different from the one he regularly plays as a top-order batter. In four of India's last five matches (after Sanju Samson's return to the XI), the Indian captain walked in after the 10th over.

On those occasions, the game state dictated that he eschew any notion of building an innings and instead look to score from his first ball in order to ensure that India keep its run-rate up in the second half of the innings. This is a role he is unlikely to do as regularly for Mumbai Indians.

Aside from conditions and role clarity, perhaps the biggest difference between the tournaments is length. India played nine games at the T20 World Cup — just over half the length of the IPL league phase. Over a longer season, a player's campaign is less likely to be defined by the vagaries of form and circumstance, with quality evening out over time.

### What to take from the World Cup

While it may not be prudent to expect World Cup form to provide much by way of a one-to-one relation to IPL form, it can be an interesting source of tactical insight.

In a game increasingly centred around role definition, franchises could gain an understanding of how they might structure their teams in order to get the best out of their players.

An excellent example is India's Player of the Tournament, Sanju Samson. Before his World Cup-winning exploits, Chennai Super Kings traded in for the 31-year-old to inject further vibrancy into a batting line-up that

